



IMPLEMENTATION STUDY

Accelerating math learning with Zearn in District 11 in NYC

P.S. 019, a K-8 school in the Bronx in NYC District 11, experienced firsthand how consistent usage of Zearn resulted in significant learning gains in math. 66% of their grade 1-8 students completed the research-based dosage of Zearn lessons, which translated to a 20 percentage point gain in school-wide math proficiency on the 2023 NYS Math test: the school ranked #2 in the district for Elementary School math performance and #1 in the district for Middle School math performance.

Led by Principal Ellen O'Brien and District 11 Superintendent Cristine Vaughan, both of whom have served as educators in the Bronx for over 20 years, P.S. 019 implemented strategies to ensure students completed the research-based dosage of 3+ grade-level Zearn lessons each week, significantly impacting math learning.

P.S. 019, The Judith K. Weiss School

- Bronx, New York
- 610 K-8 Students
- 58% Free/Reduced Lunch, 41% Black or Hispanic
- +20 percentage point gain in math proficiency from 2021-22 to 2022-23

I really believe — and my teachers really believe — that Zearn was a driving factor of our achievement gains. We saw how Zearn helped students understand and retain the key math concepts they were learning in class.

PRINCIPAL ELLEN O'BRIEN, P.S. 019

Choosing Zearn to complement core math learning in P.S. 019

After implementing a new high-quality math curriculum, Principal O'Brien observed that both teachers and students did not get results out of the existing math digital program they used alongside it. Teachers found the program difficult to use and struggled to relate the content to what they were teaching in class. Additionally, students frequently got stuck, sharing they "couldn't go any further in the program."

Recognizing the need for a solution to deepen and enhance core math learning, Principal O'Brien seized the opportunity presented by a NYC Public School math initiative that made Zearn available to District 11 schools to accelerate math learning for all students. She noted, "I was looking for a program that connected to the grade-level instruction and learning happening in the classroom. Zearn was it." Principal O'Brien launched the program with a pilot group of teachers. O'Brien noted that teachers who piloted the program said Zearn was easy to use and that "the kids like it so much more than the other program." I was sold – if you're telling me my kids like it."

In partnership with Superintendent Vaughan, O'Brien initiated a 2022-23 school-wide implementation of Zearn across grades K-8, with the goal to support all students to complete the recommended dosage of 3+ grade-level digital lessons each week. To effectively achieve this goal, the school focused on three key implementation strategies.

IMPACT COMES FROM STRONG IMPLEMENTATION

Strategies to Realize Transformative Results

1

Dedicate consistent time in or after school for students to use Zearn

2

Train all educators on Zearn's approach to grade-level learning

3

Develop routines for Zearn data review that drive student engagement

Strategies to Realize Transformative Results

1

Dedicate consistent weekly time in or after school for students to use Zearn.

Working with Superintendent Vaughan, Principal O’Brien embedded Zearn into the weekly teaching schedule across grades K-8 to ensure students had at least 90 minutes each week to complete 3+ grade-level lessons.

Across all grades, schedules included structured time during core math blocks for students to independently work on Zearn. In addition to core math blocks, teachers used Zearn flexibly to ensure students had additional time as needed including intervention, extra time, and after school.	
GRADES K-5 - Each day, students work through digital lessons on Zearn for 30 minutes after teacher instruction during the 75 minute math block. - Students had additional time during “What I Need” (WIN) blocks and after school.	GRADES 6-8 - For three days out of an 8-day block schedule, students work through digital lessons on Zearn for 30 minutes after teacher instruction during the 90 minute math block. - Students also had additional time to complete Zearn digital lessons after school.

2

Train teachers and leaders on Zearn’s approach to grade-level learning.

All teachers and school leaders attended two training sessions led by the Zearn team at the start of the school year. These trainings explored how Zearn’s digital lessons help students catch up and move forward in grade-level math learning and oriented teachers to the Zearn platform, especially reports. Teachers also experienced how digital learning on Zearn is enhanced with in-lesson prompts for paper-and-pencil work that encourage deeper engagement and allow students to transfer and strengthen their understanding.

Principal O’Brien and math leaders from each grade band — classroom teachers who were also members of the school’s math instructional leadership team — used Zearn’s playbook of implementation resources to further train teachers. These sessions took place during Monday professional development meetings with grade-level teams.

In addition to Zearn training, I modeled how to use Zearn and how to address key questions with my math instructional team. Leaders would then do the same modeling work with their teachers, pulling up the Zearn playbook of resources and walking through how to leverage data from the Zearn platform.

PRINCIPAL ELLEN O'BRIEN, P.S. 019

3 Develop systems and routines for data review that drive student engagement, agency, and motivation for math learning.

Principal O'Brien mapped out a full year plan to identify which math professional development meetings — held at the grade-band level — would be dedicated to analyze data-driven insights from the Zearn platform. In these meetings, the math instructional leaders worked with all teachers to review Zearn reports and analyze the data together, focusing on how to support students to meet the recommended dosage of 3+ grade-level lessons each week.

Teachers love the data from the Zearn platform. Alongside other tools such as in-class exit tickets and mid-unit level assessments, Zearn data helps teachers develop a whole picture of a student's math learning and make decisions to support student learning.

PRINCIPAL ELLEN O'BRIEN, P.S. 019

P.S. 019 organized schoolwide and classroom-level competitions to boost student engagement and motivation towards completing 3+ grade-level Zearn lessons weekly. Throughout these competitions, Principal O'Brien provided weekly updates and check-ins, using these communications to reinforce the value of Zearn in daily math teaching and learning. She regularly emailed grade bands to congratulate teachers who met weekly goals, ensuring their efforts were recognized.

- **Schoolwide competition:** The school set up hallway bulletin boards for classrooms to display their weekly progress towards lesson goals. This visual display encouraged students, and the class with the most progress each week was rewarded with an extra recess block.
- **Classroom competition:** Teachers offered ice cream coupons to celebrate the top five students who met their goals for the week. The student goals were focused on individual growth and improvement targets.

Looking Forward: Deepening impact

Principal O'Brien and her team, in collaboration with Zearn, are dedicated to refining their implementation strategies to sustain P.S. 019's transformative results. These include:

- Leveraging additional after-school time to ensure students complete 3+ grade-level lessons on a weekly basis
- Offering additional trainings to teachers on Zearn's approach to grade-level learning
- Refining their ongoing routines for progress data review to help drive even more student motivation for math learning



Zearn is the 501(c)(3) nonprofit educational organization behind Zearn Math, the top-rated math learning platform used by 1 in 4 elementary-school and 1 million middle-school students nationwide. Everything we do is driven by the belief that every kid is a math kid. Learn more at about.zearn.org.